relative decline. Any one of these issues would have been enough to place pressure on the resources of the British Empire, and test the abilities of the country's leaders; combined as they were in a synergy of opposition and hostility toward Britain and it created at this time the possibility of a very real crisis. It was how the British government addressed these issues in 1920 which determined just how big of a crisis would develop.

Unfortunately, the British government was inclined to make things worse for itself and in this Curzon and his Foreign Office held great responsibility for the policy that was ultimately pursued. Curzon's authority on foreign affairs in South Asia had been given further impetus by his gaining sole control of the Foreign Office towards the end of 1919. By 1920, the belief that Curzon was a driving force behind Britain's affairs in South Asia was so prevalent among contemporaries, that the foreign secretary was forced to defend himself in the House of Lords:

Incidentally I have noticed in some quarters that our policy in that part of the world is described as an act of dementia on my own part, dragging after me a body of reluctant colleagues...It is unfair to assume at any moment that an important branch of policy, even of foreign policy, is the work of any individual Minister.[190]

While it is true that government foreign policy cannot be solely blamed on one person (Curzon was supported in Persia by Milner for example, and had Cox telling him what he wanted to hear), there is no doubt that Curzon proved a stubborn obstacle in the way of a more prudent military policy in South Asia at this time. It was due to him 'more than to anyone else' that British forces were maintained in their position in Persia.[191] For while Churchill, Wilson and the Indian government were preaching military retrenchment, Curzon would do nothing to risk jeopardising an Anglo-Persian Agreement which was already clearly defunct. In allowing his ambition to override military caution Curzon must take the bulk of the blame for Britain's humiliation in Persia. The reluctance of the foreign secretary to accept a more limited role for Britain in Persia and elsewhere in